

'Why I Use A Laptop'

Jehangir Wadia, Trustee of the A H Wadia Trust, has been an avid laptop user for at least 10 years now; he currently uses a Fujitsu 7010 for everyday work.

Flexibility is the primary reason he cited for opting for a laptop over a desktop PC. According to

Wadia, you can take your entire office with you if you have a laptop—whether you're on the move, visiting your branch offices, or working at home. "Such mobility and flexibility ensures that you deliver on both—professional as well as personal demands."

weighed in at just 1.98 kg—much lighter than the next-lightest, the IBM T42, at 2.28 kg.

The Fujitsu is an ideal travel companion—it's so light that you can easily carry around that necessary extra battery pack, or even a spare mouse.

The usability of a laptop is enhanced by accessible expansion ports—it is better to have USB ports on either side of a unit than at the back; ditto for the D-Sub ports. Ports on the Acer, BenQ and Fujitsu units were nicely spread out and very easy to access.

Some laptops such as the MSI and the Zenith Strategist had touchpads with tacky keys. The Toshiba had the Windows key in the top row, and the IBMs simply did not feature a Windows key.

When the sole method of analogue input to a laptop is a touchpad, the touchpad needs to be sensitive and responsive enough to your fingers. Struggling with this will soon lead to tired fingers and a drop in productivity.

Here, the IBM Thinkpad offered the best tactile feel on both the touchpad and the keyboard. Moreover, its signature red pointing stick is a great replacement for a mouse in terms of ease of use.

The Fujitsu and the Toshiba Satellite fared equally well here. We found the IBM laptops and the Acer unit very ergonomic. IBM is to be commended for its rock-

solid build quality. When we tested onscreen readability in daylight, except for the Zenith Strategist, the remainder were nothing but eye strainers. The Fujitsu S7010 had the most difficult screen to read. As far as viewing angle goes, the Fujitsu, the Toshiba and the MSI offered good angles of 170 degrees. ACI offered the lowest at 145 degrees.

For movies, the best viewing angle of 160 degrees was offered by the Zenith Strategist. The Wipro CP had a pretty bad screen, which didn't allow for any lateral movement; we had to sit right in front of it to get a viewable image.

Although all the laptops came equipped with speakers, none came close to the Harmon Kardon speakers that shipped with the Toshiba Satellite M30.

All laptops came with either Microsoft Windows XP Professional or Home, with Wipro and Zenith being the exceptions. They didn't come preloaded with an OS at all; you are expected to either install an OS yourself or pay extra for this barest of necessities.

Performance

Laptops falling in this category are flexible enough for home and office use. This means a good workhorse should run office applications as well as a desktop PC would. To test this, we employed the Business Winstone benchmark, under which

common applications such as Microsoft Word, Excel, Outlook and Internet Explorer are run in a scripted sequence.

Here, the IBM T42 logged the highest score of 21.2, followed by the 20.7 that the Fujitsu S7010 scored. The IBM T42 also was the fastest in video encoding, and in the SiSoft Sandra 2005 synthetic benchmark suite. The T42 thus comes across as a machine that will not only perform well in most work-related applications, but one that also lends itself to minor workstation-class jobs such as rendering and image resizing and conversion.

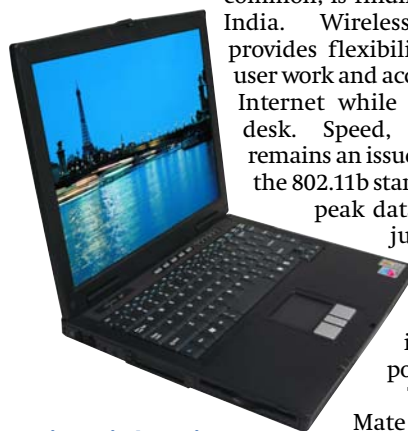
Under PCMark 2004, the Acer TravelMate 4002 scored the best, and should suffice for all computing needs—office, home or while travelling. The IBM T42 and MSI also showcased good performance.

Wi-Fi, though not very common, is finding a foothold in India. Wireless connectivity provides flexibility and lets the user work and access data and the Internet while away from the desk. Speed, however, still remains an issue, especially with the 802.11b standard, where the peak data throughput is just 11 Mbps.

Thankfully, 802.11g, with 54 Mbps, is gaining in popularity.

The Acer TravelMate 4002, with an 802.11g-based Intel card returned scores comparable to those of a wired LAN. It took just 34 seconds to copy 50 MB of data using Wi-Fi on this laptop!

We also ran a few games to test the DirectX and OpenGL performance of these machines. Since most had an integrated Intel graphics chipset, they returned very low scores, while



Wipro LittleGenius CP

Score Board		Workhorse Laptops Category		
Brand	Model	Basic Specifications	Score (Out of 100)	Price (Rs)
Acer	TravelMate 4002WNLci	Pentium M 1.6 GHz, 512 MB, Mobility RADEON 9700, 15.4-inch, 60 GB, Combo Drive, 802.11g, 10/100 Mbps, 2.98 Kg	67.64	51,999
ACI	Emerald C2	Pentium M 1.7 GHz, 256 MB, Intel 855, 14.1-inch, 40 GB, Combo Drive, 802.11b, 10/100 Mbps, 2.40 Kg	65.58	44,999
BenQ	Joybook S100U	Pentium M 1.5 GHz, 256 MB, Intel 855, 15-inch, 40 GB, Combo Drive, 802.11b, 10/100 Mbps, 2.40 Kg	57.70	79,000
Fujitsu	LifeBook S7010	Pentium M 1.6 GHz, 256 MB, Intel 855, 14.1-inch, 60 GB, Combo Drive, 802.11g, Gigabit, 1.95 Kg	63.99	130,000
IBM	T42	Pentium M 1.7 GHz, 512 MB, ATI Mobility RADEON 7500, 14.1-inch, 40 GB, Combo Drive, 802.11g, Gigabit, 2.28 Kg	60.51	124,000
IBM	R51	Pentium M 1.7 GHz, 256 MB, Intel 855, 15-inch, 40 GB, Combo Drive, 802.11g, Gigabit, 2.86 Kg	61.85	85,000
MSI	MegaBook M510C	Pentium M 1.5 GHz, 256 MB, ATI Mobility RADEON 9700, 15.4-inch, 80 GB, Combo Drive, 802.11g, Gigabit, 2.84 Kg	66.88	65,990
Toshiba	Satellite M30	Pentium M 1.6 GHz, 256 MB, GeForce FX Go5200, 15.4-inch, 40 GB, Combo Drive, 802.11b, 10/100 Mbps, 2.76 Kg	56.44	105,000
Wipro	LittleGenius 1000D	Celeron 2.4 GHz, 128 MB, SIS 315, 14.1-inch, 20 GB, CD-ROM, NA, 10/100 Mbps, 3.06 Kg	54.30	43,990
Wipro	LittleGenius CP	Pentium M 1.4 GHz, 256 MB, Intel 855, 14.1-inch, 30 GB, CD-ROM, 802.11b, 10/100 Mbps, 2.76 Kg	56.39	51,990
Zenith	Director	Pentium M 1.6 GHz, 256 MB, Intel 855, 14.1-inch, 40 GB, Combo Drive, 802.11g, 10/100 Mbps, 2.58 Kg	54.03	51,000
Zenith	Strategist	Pentium M 1.6 GHz, 256 MB, Intel 855, 15.4-inch, 40 GB, Combo Drive, 802.11g, 10/100 Mbps, 2.82 Kg	58.31	57,500

For the complete scoreboard, log on to www.thinkdigit.com